

Topic B2: Poverty, Public Health and the Growth of Government in Britain, 1830-75

relief of poverty in Britain from 1830 to 1875, on the development of public health policies in these years and on their impact on popular health. The theme which links both issues is how and why governments responded to pressure for change, and the ways in which this period saw a growth in the responsibilities assumed by the state.

It should be appreciated that the content bullet points should not be taken as discrete entities. Questions may require students to draw on the content of more than one bullet point in framing a response. There are ways in which they relate to one another and mesh together. For example, students could draw on material from bullet points 1, 2 and 4 to explore the role of government in key areas of provision.

The first bullet point relates to the unreformed Poor Law. Students should have knowledge and understanding of the key features of the old Poor Law and how it operated. Students should have knowledge of the main systems of outdoor relief operating at the beginning of the 19th century: Speenhamland, the Roundsman system and the Labour rate. Knowledge of the grounds on which the Poor Law was attacked in the early 19th century and why it became increasingly controversial is required. They should also have knowledge and understanding of why the Royal Commission of Enquiry into the Workings of the Poor Law was established in 1832 and of recommendations made and the reasons for them. Knowledge and understanding of the contribution to poor law policy made by Edwin Chadwick is expected.

The second bullet point requires students to have knowledge and understanding of the main provisions of the Poor Law Amendment Act and of the changes that these brought about. Students should know how the New Poor Law operated in the years to 1875 with regard to the treatment of paupers in workhouses, the operation of the workhouse test and outdoor relief and why it was so controversial. 'Reactions' to the New Poor Law encompasses the support and opposition its implementation engendered among different social and political groups and why there was stronger opposition in the north of England. Students should also appreciate the implications of changes in the central administration of the Poor Law to 1875. Knowledge of the work of the Poor Law Board and Local Government Board is required in order to show continuity and change in the approach to the administration of poor relief in the period. In particular, students will be expected to know about the Central Poor Law Commission, its work and the problems faced by the assistant commissioners in initially implementing the 1834 Act.

The third bullet point relates to the importance of cholera in the 1830s and 1840s and to why outbreaks and the spread of cholera provoked so much debate on the nature and provision of public health. The phrase 'the roles of Edwin Chadwick and John Snow' relates to the significance of the work of these two individuals in public health, including their impact on debate and legislation in this area. Students should understand why public health provision was a controversial question both nationally and locally. The focus of this bullet point is primarily on the factors creating pressure for greater intervention to improve public health. It links closely with bullet point 4 which focuses more directly on legislation and the nature of provision for public health. Students should understand the relationship between pressures and changes throughout the period.

The fourth bullet point relates to public health provision. Students should have knowledge and understanding of the nature of public health provision in the years 1848–75 and the reasons for the legislation and for opposition to it. Students should have knowledge and understanding of the main terms of the 1848 and 1875 acts, as well as of the circumstances of their introduction. Students should also be aware that improved public health provision involved the interrelationship of several factors, for example: improved understanding of the nature of and transmission of diseases; changing attitudes to intervention; and the availability of the technology and civil engineering skills involved in large-scale construction of systems of water supply and sewerage. To exemplify the last factor, they should have knowledge and understanding of the work of Joseph Bazalgette in London. They should also be aware of the wider context of other local public health initiatives and legislation in the period. Although questions will not be set which focus specifically and exclusively on any local legislation, local case studies could be used to illustrate the attitudes to and the problems of implementing schemes for improving public health provision. Improvements in Leeds are well documented and could be used as an example. Questions will not be set which focus directly and exclusively on housing policy in these years but students should understand the impact of housing on health.